That the BJP became a more attractive party to Indian women after 2014 is clear. The interesting question is whether this reflected a deeper social and political churn in India or was the outcome of a change in the BJP and the result of new policies targeted at women. In other words, did the party start doing something dramatically different to usher in this gender shift? Or was it only the beneficiary of wider social changes? The evidence is overwhelming that the women's vote shifted after the party made major changes in its approach to women.

The BJP had taken a mahila turn in 1980 and started talking the talk. But women voters did not shift in large enough numbers until it made significant changes in its outreach and started being perceived by many women as walking the talk too. These changes are encapsulated in four specific targeted interventions that were personally led by Modi, who has had a marked focus on women in his public messaging. At the organisational level, after 2014, the BJP made major changes in its party organisation, giving more proportional representation to women nationally (in government, party structure and as election candidates) than any other national political party in India. At the policy level, it was driven by a targeted deepening of women-focused initiatives in governmental development programmes and a focus on publicising these. Of course, some of these programmes were built on ideas developed and piloted by Manmohan Singh's UPA, but the Modi government doubled down on them, scaled up the initiatives and built a new political narrative around them. At the discourse level, the cultural superstructure was driven by the RSS, whose thinking on women has also evolved over time.

Strategy 1: 'When a Woman Gets Convinced in a Family, the Whole Family Gets Convinced': Modi's Women Outreach and Discourse

An examination of Narendra Modi's speeches as prime minister reveals that he speaks more about women than he does about core BJP issues like defence, security, terrorism, Hindutva or Pakistan. This is a striking revelation of how crucial women are to his political